adopting newer PCs that gave them a new experience powered by cloud and mobile solutions. Whereas, 63 per cent of SMEs believe they can better protect data on new PCs. It also suggested that 58 per cent of SMEs find that adopting newer PCs can reduce overall maintenance costs, while 41 per cent SMEs believe that newer PCs can improve employee productivity.

PCs are ever-pervasive devices today, and are the main operating platforms for most SMEs in India. Priyadarshi Mohapatra, general manager, Microsoft India Consumer and Device Sales, shares that, every three in 10 SMEs in India have PCs that are older than four years, which significantly increases maintenance costs.

Underlying challenges

Respondents to the study identified their top business priorities to be business growth, productivity and profitability. They are relying on IT for a response to business problems. Most important IT priorities include investment, mobility, cloud solutions and managed services.

Anurag Agrawal, chief analyst, Techaisle, shares, "We found that the main barriers to migrating to new devices are the inability of legacy applications to run on newer operating systems and the lack of budget. However, benefits of adopting modern device strategies outweigh the concerns.

He explains that, SMEs tend to focus on short-term costs, an approach that proves to be ineffective at times in the long run. "The choice between maintaining old PCs and replacing these with newer ones is one such area," he adds.

Agarwal believes that SMEs should re-evaluate their budget and strategies, keeping in mind the higher cost of maintaining older PCs and the greater cumulative impact on the budget in the long run.

According to the study, in India, more than 61 per cent of PCs used by SMEs are still on older versions of Windows. Upgrading to Windows 10 modern devices will provide a more familiar, secure and efficient experience.

Moving forward

Mohapatra adds that latest features in Windows 10 aim to provide a platform for these companies and their employees to ensure optimal mobility and support for business applications. While sharing Microsoft's strategy in this context, Mohapatra informs that Microsoft aims to continue collaboration with its OEM partner ecosystem to provide more affordable price points for PCs and laptops, offering SME-related options based on their size and requirements.

SMEs account for 95 per cent of the total number of Indian companies. On a national scale, if all these SMEs decide to move on to newer systems, financial savings can be enormous.

"Computers and connections open the way for SME digitalisation and automation, increasing returns, scale and production. By deploying PCs that support complex tasks and scale, these companies must invest in upgrading their processing power," concludes Prakash Mallya, general manager - sales and marketing, Intel India.

3 SMART TECHNOLOGY To REDUCE ADULTERATION In DAIRY

CEERI's cost-effective handheld tester can help dairy businesses stay more informed about the milk they provide

Food adulteration is a serious problem in the food processing industry today. Adulteration involves the introduction of chemical substances to food and beverages to improve their appearance or volume, and increase sales appeal. These chemicals are often hazardous to health, detrimental to food quality and can lead to severe complications for consumers.

Moreover, distributed food products that remain unevaluated for adulteration before reaching buyers lead to health complications. This directly affects brand reputation and, eventually, business of the food manufacturer. To help food business owners as well as consumers be cautious about the quality of the food being sold, CSIR-CEERI has developed a technology that acts as an electronic tongue.

Challenges in dairy adulteration

Milk adulteration has been one of the most prevalent nuisances in the food industry. At the time, chemical tests were the popular choice when it came to adulteration detection. Popular milk adulterants in India include urea, salt, detergent, caustic soda, ammonium sulphate, boric acid and hydrogen peroxide, among others.

Chemical test processes are time-, resource- and effort-heavy, as a specific adulterant can be detected with a specific reaction only. A single reaction takes

Under-test prototype of the milk fat tester